I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings

By Maya Angelou

Note: Items in brackets or parentheses are to be acted out, not spoken.

MAYA: In the Christian Methodist Episcopal Church the children's section was on the right, cater-cornered from the pew that held those women called the Mothers of the Church. On Sundays, it was ordained by Momma that Bailey and I occupy the first row, called the mourners' bench. I thought we were placed in front because Momma was proud of us, but Bailey assured me that she just wanted to keep her grandchildren under her thumb and eye.

INTRODUCTION

Sitting in church patiently and quietly is tough for children at the best of times, but sometimes events unfold (even during church) that stretches the limits of any child to remain solemn and serious.

You know what I'm talking about: Church Giggles. And once you get the Church Giggles, it's hard to stop! You immediately try to think about something serious . . . like Moses. That guy had a serious beard . . . Think about Moses. For the love of Moses' beard, stop laughing!

And you win, for about 30 seconds. But then you spot a comrade – someone else trying to hold in the Church Giggles and you lose all hope of recovery.

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MAYA: People spoke of Momma as a good-looking woman and some said she used to be right pretty. I saw only her power and strength. She was tall, and her hands were so large they could span my head from ear to ear. Each Sunday the minister would announce,

MINISTER: We will now be led in a hymn by Sister Henderson.

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MAYA: And each Sunday she looked up with amazement at the preacher and asked,

SISTER HENDERSON (MOMMA): Me? *[After a second of assuring herself that she indeed was being called upon, she laid down her handbag and slowly folded her handkerchief. This was placed neatly on top of the purse, then she leaned on the bench in front and pushed herself to a standing position, and then she opened her mouth and the song jumped out as if it had only been waiting for the right time to make an appearance.] [Insert hymn phrase of your choice here]*

MAYA: That Sunday Reverend Thomas took his text from Deuteronomy. Deuteronomy was my favorite book in the Bible. The laws were so clear, that I knew if a person truly wanted to avoid being roasted forever in the devil's fire, all she had to do was memorize Deuteronomy. I also liked the way the word rolled off the tongue. Deuteronomy.

Bailey and I sat alone on the front bench, the wooden slats pressing hard on our behinds. I would have wriggled just a bit, but each time I looked over at Momma, she seemed to threaten, "Move and I'll tear you up," so, I sat still. The church ladies were warming up behind me with a few "hallelujahs" and "Praise the Lords" and "Amens", and the preacher hadn't really moved into the meat. It was going to be a hot service.

I saw Sister Monroe, her gold crown glinting when she opened her mouth. She couldn't get to church every Sunday, so she made up by shouting so hard when she did make it that she shook the whole church. It took three women and sometimes a man or two to hold her.

Once when she hadn't been to church for a few months she got the spirit and started shouting, throwing her arms around and jerking her body, so that the ushers went over to hold her down, but she tore herself away from them and ran up to the pulpit.

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SISTER MONROE: *[She stood in front of the altar, shaking like a fresh caught trout. She screamed at Reverend Taylor.]* "Preach it. I say, preach it."

MAYA: Naturally he kept on preaching.

SISTER MONROE: *[Then she screamed an extremely fierce]* "I said, preach it"

MAYA: . . . and stepped up on the altar. The Reverend kept on. Sister Monroe made a quick break and caught the minister by the sleeve of his jacket and his coattail, then she rocked him from side to side.

I have to say this for our minister, he never stopped giving us the lesson. The usher board fairly ran to the minister's aid. Two of the deacons, in their shiny Sunday suits, joined the ladies in white on the pulpit, and each time they pried Sister Monroe loose from the preacher he took another deep breath and kept on preaching, and Sister Monroe grabbed him in another place, and more firmly. Reverend Taylor was helping his rescuers as much as possible by jumping around when he got a chance. His voice at one point got so low it sounded like a roll of thunder, then

SISTER MONROE: Preach it!

MAYA: Then the pandemonium spread. The spirit infused Deacon Jackson and Sister Willson, the chairman of the usher board, at the same time. Deacon Jackson gave a scream

DEACON JACKSON: *[like a falling tree,]* Aaaaahhhh!

MAYA: . . . and punched Reverend Taylor on the arm. It must have hurt. Reverend Taylor jerked around surprised, and punched Deacon Jackson. Then Sister Willson caught his tie, looped it over her fist, and pressed down on him. Next

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thing all three of them were down on the floor behind the altar. Their legs spiked out like kindling wood. Sister Monroe got up and walked off.

SISTER MONROE: *(singing)* I came to Jesus, as I was, worried, wound, and sad, I found in Him a resting place and He has made me glad.

MAYA: The minister took advantage of already being on the floor and asked in a choky little voice if the church would kneel with him to offer a prayer of thanksgiving. He said we had been visited with a mighty spirit, and let the whole church say "Amen."

On the next Sunday, Sister Monroe's fuse was already lit, and she sizzled somewhere to the right behind me. I saw the ushers from the left side of the church near the big windows begin to move discreetly, like pallbearers, toward Sister Monroe's bench. Bailey jogged my knee. When the incident with Sister Monroe, which we always called "the incident," had taken place, we had been too astounded to laugh. But for weeks after, all we needed to send us into violent outbursts of laughter was a whispered "Preach it" Anyway, he pushed my knee, covered his mouth and whispered,

BAILEY: I say, preach it.

MAYA: I looked toward Momma over the collection table, hoping that a look from her would root me safely to my sanity. But Momma was staring at Sister Monroe with a severe look. But Sister Monroe's voice had already reached the danger point.

SISTER MONROE: Preach it!

MAYA: Bailey nudged me again.

BAILEY: *[in a whisper]* I say, preach it

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SISTER MONROE: *(echoing him loudly)* I say, preach it!

MAYA: Two deacons wedged themselves around Brother Jackson as a preventive measure and two large determined-looking men walked down the aisle toward Sister Monroe. Elder Thomas made the regrettable mistake of increasing his volume. Then suddenly, Sister Monroe broke through the people trying to hem her in, and [ran] up to the pulpit.

SISTER MONROE: I say, preach it!

BAILEY: Hot dog . . . Damn . . . She's going to beat his butt.

MAYA: But Reverend Thomas didn't intend to wait for that, so as Sister Monroe approached the pulpit from the right, he started descending from the left, preaching and moving. He finally stopped right in front of the collection table, which put him almost in our laps, and Sister Monroe rounded the altar on his heels, followed by the deacons, ushers, some unofficial members and a few of the bigger children. Just as the elder said . . .

REVEREND THOMAS: Great God of Mount Nebo . . .

MAYA: Sister Monroe hit him on the back of his head with her purse. Twice. Before he could bring his lips together, his teeth jumped out of his mouth and landed right by my foot. Bailey pinched me and said without moving his lips,

BAILEY: I'd like to see him eat dinner now.

MAYA: Now, I dreaded laughing in church. If I lost control, two things were certain to happen. I would surely pee, and just as surely get a whipping. And this time I would probably die because everything was funny — Sister Monroe, and Momma trying to keep her quiet with those threatening looks, and Bailey whispering

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BAILEY: Preach it

MAYA: . . . and Elder Thomas with his lips flapping loose like tired elastic.

REVEREND THOMAS: *(gummed without his teeth)* Naked I came into the world, and naked I shall go out.

MAYA: Bailey's laugh had worked its way up through his body and was escaping through his nose.

BAILEY: *(Snort. Snort. Snort)*

MAYA: I didn't try any longer to hold back the laugh, I just opened my mouth and released sound. *[Laughs]* Momma said,

MOMMA: Sister!

MAYA: . . . but the bench was greasy and I slid off onto the floor. There was more laughter in me trying to get out. I didn't know there was that much in the whole world. It pressed at all my body openings, forcing everything in its path. I cried and hollered, passed gas and peed.

I didn't see Bailey descend to the floor, but I rolled over once and he was kicking and screaming too. Each time we looked at each other we howled louder than before, and though he tried to say something, he was only able to get out

BAILEY: I say, preach.

MAYA: . . . And then I rolled over onto Uncle Willie's rubber-tipped cane.

UNCLE WILLIE: *[The one side of his mouth pulled down as it usually did when he cried (it also pulled down when he laughed). He stuttered,]* I'm gonna whip you this time myself.

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MAYA: I have no memory of how we got out of church and into the parsonage, but in that parlor, Bailey and I received the whipping of our lives. Uncle Willie ordered us between licks to stop crying. I tried to, but Bailey yelled so loud and disturbed what was left of the service, the minister's wife came out and asked Uncle Willie to quiet us down.

For weeks after that I stood on laughter's cliff and any funny thing could hurl me off far below.

Each time Bailey said "Preach it" to me, I hit him as hard as I could and cried.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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